Stargazing

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/67063141.

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Not Rated

Archive Warning:
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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
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by CyberWolf_1013

Summary

Adora is out by Brightmoon lake one evening. She's been thinking a lot lately. Things that the old her would never allow herself to think. However, now that the war is over, maybe it'll be easier to voice those thoughts. Especially when Catra comes searching for her.

Notes

This is a short something that I had in my folder for the longest time. Don't read too much into it. I haven't written anything She-Ra-Reboot in a long while (except for the Pride crossover but that wasn't exclusive, so I don't count it) ...Soooo I figured, between chapters of my Hazbin WIP, I'd clean it up and share.

Yay.

The air felt crisp and cool against Adora's skin, carrying the scent of trees and damp earth from the Whispering Woods bordering the large shimmering lake on the edge of Brightmoon's royal grounds. The vast expanse of the star-filled night sky, newly revealed after the destruction of Horde Prime, blazed with unfamiliar constellations. It was a breathtaking tapestry woven with stars she'd never seen before. Brightmoon Castle, a beacon of hope and hard-won peace, stood silhouetted against the darkening horizon, its stone walls a comforting presence against the vastness of the chilly night. Adora sighed as she gazed upwards, her reflection shimmering faintly in the still water. Her usual ponytail was in place and the worn red jacket, she still preferred compared to the more regal attire, kept the bite of chill off her skin. Even the quiet beauty of this night couldn't fully erase the memories that seemed to cling to her even after putting the echoes of battle and the weight of her past in the Horde far behind her. Maybe it wasn't so far behind her after all.

Tonight, however, a different kind of weight pressed upon her. It wasn't her past in the Horde, or the war, it wasn't the ever-present shadow of leadership that she couldn't seem to escape, but a more silently persistent unease. It had been months since the final battle, months of rebuilding, of healing, of trying to forge a lasting peace. Months of… uncertainty. A quiet hum of anxiety vibrated in her chest, a subtle tremor in the carefully constructed peace in her heart. The daily routine of guiding Etheria towards a brighter future, felt… insufficient. Adora could feel that something was missing.

This feeling had been growing since the end of the war, since the threat of Horde Prime had been lifted, and sometimes it overwhelmed her. Especially when Catra was nearby. The former Horde Captain now occupied a precarious position within Brightmoon – a hesitant ally, a grudging friend, a constant source of both fascination and apprehension. Their past, a complicated pattern of loyalty, betrayal, rivalry, and a love as fiercely complex as it was undeniable, hung heavily between them. Their relationship remained fragile, a delicate balance that could shatter

at any moment. Tonight, as Adora watched the stars, she thought of her oldest friend, of their history, of the words and the lingering emotions that still pulsed between them.

'Tomorrow is another day,' Adora thought, *'another patrol of the castle walls that needed to be carried out, another urgent matter Glimmer or the Princess's need help with… or maybe a different type of mission, entirely.'*

Adora sank to the cool grass, the damp ground is a surprisingly comfortable cushion. A sigh escapes her lips with a long, drawn-out sound. The stars, brilliant and unfamiliar, offer a cold solace. Brightmoon castle was once a place she felt was her only choice for her future, she could live with that then, but now Adora felt like she had a say in what happened to her. The endless cycle of meetings, the delicate dance of political maneuvering orchestrated by Glimmer, the constant stream of reports and requests – it all weighed heavily on her. She's a soldier, was raised to be from birth, never meant to be a politician. The intricacies of courtly life bored her, not to mention how confusing the endless discussions about trade agreements and alliances were, all of it was a constant strain compared to the vast, unexplored world stretching beyond the castle walls.

A part of her yearned to explore the uncharted territories of Etheria, to discover new lands, new cultures, to truly experience the peace she fought so hard to achieve. But the thought of leaving, of abandoning her responsibilities, fills her with a familiar pang of guilt. She's always put the needs of others first, a habit ingrained from her time in the Horde. But this time, for once, she wants to consider her own desires. This desire, however, is inextricably linked to another.

Adora's want for adventure and her drive to explore the unknown wouldn't be complete without having Catra there with her to experience it too. The thought brings a warmth to her chest, a pleasant contrast to the chill night air. Catra, with her fierce independence and sharp wit, her unpredictable moods and undeniable charm, is the one person who truly understood the

weight of Adora's past and the turmoil within her. She’s also the only person who can possibly understand the subtle tremor that runs through her heart at the mere mention of leaving.

Leaving Etheria alone is not an option.

But not leaving Etheria with Catra feels like dying slowly.

The image of Catra, her dark hair catching the moonlight, her expressive tail twitching in excitement, flashes through Adora’s mind. Then as if her thoughts had summoned the Magicat a familiar voice spoke up behind her.

"Hey, Adora."

Catra’s voice, laced with a hint of her usual tease and sarcasm, broke through the quiet night. The sound is close, too close, and Adora jumps with a jerk to look over her shoulder. Adora’s heart thuds against her ribs. She hadn’t even heard Catra approach over the soft grass. She finds Catra standing a few feet away, her usual confident posture softened by a subtle hesitancy. Her tail twitches lightly, a nervous gesture that betrays the calm she’s trying to project.

Catra's mixed eyes, blue and yellow, hold a curious intensity. She’s been searching for Adora since dinner, and the slightly breathless quality of her greeting suggests a mixture of concern and impatience. The moonlight catches the fine fur that coats her body, highlighting the subtle tan and brown tones.

“Catra,” Adora breathes, a mixture of relief and a touch of nervousness coloring her voice. The unspoken question hangs in the air between them: *What are you doing here?*

Catra nervously shifts her weight from one foot to the other, her gaze dropping to the ground before meeting Adora's again. "I… I've been looking for you," she admits, her voice barely above a whisper. The usual playful edge is absent, replaced by something vulnerable, something raw.

A comfortable silence settles between them, broken only by the gentle lapping of the lake against the shore. The quiet between them is as potent as any spoken phrase, a conversation without words, pulled from their own deep history with each other.

Slowly, Adora extends a hand towards Catra. "It's cold," she says, her tone an invitation, "come sit with me."

Catra hesitates for only a moment before taking Adora’s hand. Her touch sends a shiver down Adora’s spine, a mixture of anticipation and apprehension. As she sits down beside the blonde, their shoulders brush, sending another wave of warmth through Adora. The silence between them isn't awkward this time. The stars above them seem to hold their breath, waiting.

The quiet stretches between them, comfortable, yet charged with emotion. Adora feels Catra's warmth beside her, a comforting weight that she’d missed for so long, and now had back again. The scent of the forest and damp earth mixes with the faint, musky fragrance of Catra's fur, a familiar and oddly comforting aroma. Adora steals a glance at Catra, catching the glint of light in her eyes. The intensity of Catra's gaze is both unnerving and intoxicating.

"I… I didn't know where you’d gone earlier..." Catra finally says, her voice a low murmur that barely disturbs the stillness of the night. “...I wasn’t worried though.” She avoids Adora's eyes, her gaze fixed on the shimmering surface of the lake.

Adora shrugged, a small, almost imperceptible movement. "Couldn't sleep," she admitted with a rueful grin, knowing the words Catra wouldn’t admit to yet.

The blonde reaches out, her fingers brushing against Catra's arm, a tentative touch that says more than her words could. Catra doesn't pull away. Instead, she leans slightly closer, her body angled more towards the warmth of Adora. “What are you even doing out here in the dark anyway, dummy? You’ll catch a cold or something.” The light fur along her arm bristles where Adora

trailed her fingers and a blush, too light to be seen in the darkness, spread across her face. Catra ignores the heat increasing under her fur.

"I've just been thinking…" Adora begins, her voice quiet and thoughtful above the gentle lapping of the nearby water. She hesitates, unsure how to articulate the swirling thoughts within her. The words feel clumsy on her tongue. It all sounded much clearer in her head.

"About what?" Catra asked softly, her voice a breath in the darkening night.

"About… leaving," Adora manages, a shiver down her spine that had nothing to do with the chill in the air. The confession hangs between them, a fragile truth. "Thinking about exploring… about seeing what's beyond Brightmoon." The words tumble out in a rush of pent-up feelings and ignored thoughts.

Catra's tail gives a sharp flick which Adora knew to be a subtle sign of her interest and curiosity. She turns her head slightly, her gaze meeting Adora's. "And…?" She prompts, her voice laced with slight apprehension at the thought of Adora leaving, again.

Adora took a deep breath, the cool night air filling her lungs. "And… I wouldn't go without you," she confesses, her voice clear and unwavering. The words are a declaration of both of her current desires. Adventure and her unwavering attachment to Catra. The stars above them seem to shimmer with approval. The watching galaxy waiting to see where the young hero would wind up. It's filled with the promise of an unwritten future that has finally overcome the pains and betrayals of a broken past. The stars, unfamiliar constellations beyond Etheria, twinkle above them, a silent audience.

"Where would we go?" Catra murmurs, her voice barely audible above the gentle lapping of the lake. The question is said as a playful challenge to draw out more of what Adora was really

thinking in that blonde head of hers. Catra's tail swishes in the grass behind them.

Thoughts began racing in Adora's head at the whirlwind of possibilities and anxieties opening in her mind. The familiar comfort of Brightmoon, the weight of her responsibilities as She-Ra, all seem distant right now. She thinks of the endless expanse of Etheria, a whole planet she barely knows, one she vowed to protect. "She-Ra is the guardian of Etheria, right?" Adora says, the question more to herself than Catra. The deep feeling of needing a justification of her actions takes hold and Adora turns to Catra with a pleading look in her eyes. A familiar expression as she desperately attempts to rationalize her own desires.

"Yeah…" Catra slowly nods along.

Adora's stormy blue eyes drift towards the dark silhouette of the Whispering Woods, a place that holds both painful memories, and good. Where the beginning of her transformation into She-Ra truly began. "Well, Brightmoon and the Whispering Woods aren't all of Etheria. There's so much more out there than I ever thought could be when we were kids. Do you remember, Catra?" Her voice cracks slightly, her emotion catching in her throat. She remembers the endless drills, the brutal training, the unwavering loyalty demanded by the Horde. There are also memories of cuddling up in the lower bunk in the coldest winter nights, succeeding in their trials even if they were holding each other up at the end, and dreaming of getting to live their lives however they wanted. It was the complex bond that had forged them both.

Leaning more into Adora as she found warmth from the cool evening, Catra allowed the blonde to pull her close. The proximity igniting a familiar feeling. She nodded slowly as her eyes reflected the light of Etheria's multiple moons. A mixture of melancholy and longing clearly evident in her lost expression. "Yeah, I do. I remember," she whispers. Catra's voice is laced with a bittersweet nostalgia. "We thought the Fright Zone was the whole world. Now... now there's all of this." Her gesture encompasses the starlit sky, vast and infinite, a reflection of the possibilities that lie

before them. A faint smile graces her lips, a rare glimpse of vulnerability. "And we have a spaceship," she adds, a teasing glint in her eyes. "Albeit an ancient one... that's being reconstructed right now... but still, we could even go beyond Etheria someday." The words hang in the air, heavy with unspoken dreams and the thrill of the unknown.

The truth is that neither of them really know what they are going to do, but they are together, and for now that's all that really matters. The wind rustles the leaves in the nearby woods, carrying with it the scent of something unknown and unwritten. And, at least for tonight, those distant adventures would remain that way. They had each other and that was enough.

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